David Silva

PHOTOGRAPHY

FREE FIELD GUIDE

# The Car Meet Field Guide

Proven formulas for angles, light, settings and handheld technique, plus the story shots: the cars and the people who love them.

Car meets, club days and your first planned shoots.
For a camera with one lens or a zoom, with notes for phones.
Read it on a screen, or print it on A5 and write on the planning pages. The quick cards come with it.



Cover: Cars on the Green, London, October 2026. Every photo in this guide is mine.

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# How to use this guide

I made the first version of this guide for myself, for a Porsche Club meet at Blackbushe Airport. It worked so well that I've rebuilt it for everyone: the same formulas, every page with a diagram or a recipe, and the weather, positioning and scouting I'd been meaning to write down.

## Two parts

- **This guide**: read it the night before. Diagrams, recipes, tables, the why.
- **The quick cards**: on your phone at the meet. One situation per card, five lines, swipe to the one you need.

## Kit it assumes

- Any interchangeable-lens camera. My examples are a Nikon Z6 II with one lens, a 35 mm f/1.8, and the angle tables give zoom ranges and what to do with a 35 mm prime.
- Phone shooters: page 24 is yours, and most recipes work on a phone.

### This guide comes with my newsletter

Plain emails about what I'm learning: photographing cars and building a photography business. No spam, unsubscribe any time. If someone passed this guide to you, join here: https://davidslv.photography/field-guide/

## The three rules I never break

- **Photograph the people.** The cars are the reason; the people are the story.
- **Never crop through anyone's head.**
- **Ask before you touch anything**: doors, wheels, lights, the car itself.

### The target for a morning

Ten hero frames: six of cars (a front three-quarter, a rear three-quarter, a signature detail, a wide of the venue, an arrival or departure, one more) and four of people (an owner with their car, a conversation, hands or wear, the crowd). Four strong frames beat forty average ones.

### What's inside

Plan 3 · Light and weather 4 to 11 · Exposure 12 · Angles 13 to 16 · Positioning 17 · Scouting 18 to 19 · Details and signatures 20 to 22 · Settings and handheld 23 to 24 · Phones 24 · Motion 25 · Etiquette and people 26 to 27 · Editing 28 · Checklist 29 · Your meet, to fill in 30 to 34 · Sources 35

# One-page plan for the day

Times are relative to when you arrive. Aim to be there **30 to 45 minutes before the meet officially starts**: empty spaces, cars arriving, owners relaxed and chatty, and the best of the light before the crowd builds. Turn up early, stay late, be curious.

| When | Block | Shoot this | Done when |
|---|---|---|---|
| 0:00 to 0:20 | Warm up | Walk the venue (page 18). Run the angle formula once on any car to set exposure, white balance and polariser. Cars arriving at the entrance (page 25). | Settings locked, 3 sharp arrivals |
| 0:20 to 1:00 | Heroes | Pick 3 or 4 standout cars before the crowd: front three-quarter, rear three-quarter, low front, profile. Ask owners first (page 26). | 4 clean car heroes |
| 1:00 to 1:30 | Signatures | Badges, lights, wings, wheels, interiors, a lineup of generations (pages 20 to 22). | 6 to 10 details |
| 1:30 to 2:15 | The venue | Compression down the rows, one car small in a big space, the building or landmark that says where you are. | 2 venue frames |
| 2:15 to 3:00 | Story | Owners with their cars, conversations, hands, wear, the crowd at its busiest (page 27). | 4 story frames |
| Last 30 min | Departures | Panning at the exit, the last few people still talking, a final wide of the emptying car park. | 1 or 2 motion frames |

**If time collapses**

Prioritise: 1) an owner with their car, 2) a front three-quarter hero, 3) one signature detail, 4) one wide of the venue.

**Star as you go**

Star or rate the keepers in camera during lulls, so the edit starts on the drive home.

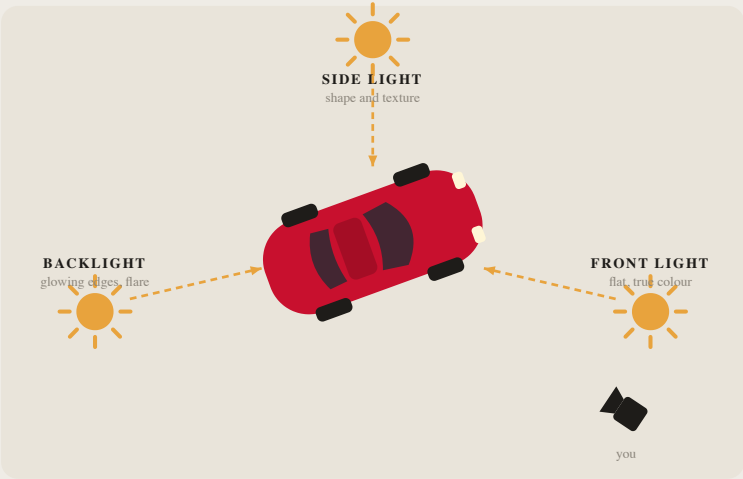
# Read the light first

A car is a curved mirror. You photograph what it reflects as much as the car itself. Big, soft light (cloud, open sky after sunset) draws smooth highlights along the body lines. Small, hard light (the midday sun) puts hot spots on the curves and black shadows underneath.

## Where is the light coming from?

- **Side light** shows shape and texture: the lines, the curves, the wheel arches. Usually the best.
- **Front light** (sun behind you) is flat but shows true colour. Watch your shadow.
- **Backlight** (shooting towards the sun) gives glowing edges and flare. Block the sun with the car.

| Weather | Best for | Page |
|---|---|---|
| Overcast | whole cars, colour, faces | 5 |
| Hard sun | details, shadows, shade | 6 |
| Low sun | shape, long shadows, glow | 7 |
| Rain | reflections, umbrellas | 8 |
| Fog and frost | atmosphere, simple shapes | 9 |
| Dusk and night | lights on, the open sky | 10 |




## Plan with three apps

- **Met Office**: hourly forecast, cloud and rain maps, warnings.
- **Clear Outside**: cloud cover by height, dew point and frost, hour by hour. Good for guessing fog.
- **The Photographer's Ephemeris** or **PhotoPills**: where the sun will be, and when, at any spot on a map.

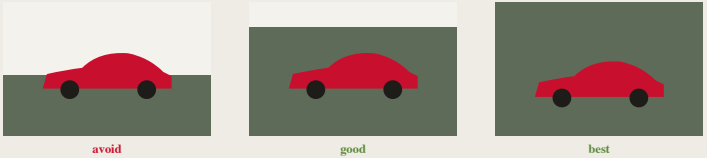
# Overcast: the giant softbox

**Overcast is a gift for cars.** The cloud is one giant softbox: no harsh hot spots on the paint, gentle reflections that trace every curve, strong, even colour (reds look rich and true). The catch is the sky: a white or flat grey sky is far brighter than the car and blows out easily.

- **Expose for the car, not the sky.** Expect **+0.3 to +0.7 EV** when the car fills the frame, and **-0.3 to -0.7 EV** when lots of white sky is in shot.
- **Frame the sky out or keep it thin**: shoot slightly down on the car, or go low so the car sits against clean grey tarmac.
- **Polariser** on paint and glass. Rotate it while watching the bonnet and the windscreen.
- **ISO 400 to 800** is fine on any modern camera: clean files and safe shutter speeds in dull light.
- **White balance a touch warm** (Cloudy, about 6000K), so skin and reds don't go cold and blue.
- Light fades earlier in autumn and winter: do your heroes first.




Belgrave Square, February 2026: grey light, true colour. f/2.5, 1/800 s, ISO 400.

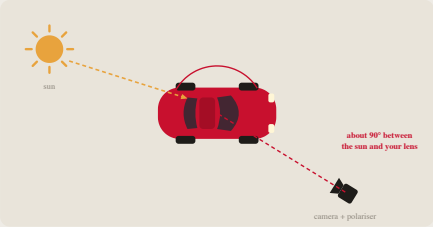



Sky blown: avoid. Sky thin: good. No sky, tarmac behind: best.

# Hard sun and the polariser

Midday sun puts hot white spots on every curve and black shadows under the sills. It's often what you get at a meet, so work with it.

- **Find shade** for whole cars: under trees or beside a building the light goes soft and even. Watch for dappled light.
- **Half light, half shadow.** A car partly in shade shows its shape; flat light everywhere hides it.
- **Polariser at 90° to the sun** (diagram): it cuts glare off glass and deepens paint. It does little when you shoot towards or away from the sun, and it costs 1 to 2 stops.
- I've only just started using one. My first meet with a polariser was Cars on the Green in October 2026: a ProMaster 62mm circular polariser on the 35mm. This is how it works on paper; I'm still learning it in practice.
- You can't remove every reflection on a curved car: choose a clear windscreen or clean flanks, then re-check after every move.
- Too much polariser makes windows unnaturally black, and can show rainbow stress patterns in toughened side glass.
- Shoot details, shadows on tarmac and graphic shapes; save the heroes for softer light.






Hard sun at Cars on the Green, October 2026: my first meet with the polariser. f/2, 1/640 s, ISO 200.



Same morning: deep orange paint, little glare on the flank. f/2, 1/320 s, ISO 320.

# Low sun and golden hour

In a British winter you get golden light at lunchtime: in London the sun climbs only about **15°** on the shortest day. Golden hour proper is the sun between the horizon and about 6° above it.

- **Sun to the side of the car**: it rakes along the flank and shows every line.
- **Backlight for glowing edges**: shoot towards the sun and hide the sun itself behind the car or a tree.
- **Use the long shadows**: they're half the picture.
- Expose for the bright side; let the shadows go dark.
- Drivers are dazzled: stand well clear of moving cars.
- Use civil twilight times from your sun app rather than a fixed 'blue hour': definitions vary.



The Fairmile, April 2026, 19:36: the sun low behind the cars, glowing edges, the paint lit from the side. f/5, 1/320 s, ISO 640.

**Quick test**

Turn a full circle around the car before you shoot. The side where the paint suddenly glows is your side.

# Rain and wet tarmac

Wet tarmac darkens and reflects lights and colour, paint gets deeper, water beads on a waxed bonnet, and umbrellas go up.

- **Go low** to catch the car in the wet tarmac and puddles: the lens just above the water, like my Cayman on the right.
- **Beading**: close-ups at f/1.8 to f/2.8; a 35 mm focuses to about 25 cm.
- **Raise ISO** rather than letting the shutter fall below 1/125 s. On 5 January 2025 I shot at ISO 5000 all morning.
- **People and umbrellas**: huddles, colour, steam from coffee.
- A dry car on a wet patch can look like a leak: wet the area or move.

> **Gear**
>
> Most cameras are weather-sealed, not waterproof. Rain cover or a shower cap, lens hood on, a microfibre cloth in your pocket, and wipe the front element often.




My own Cayman in a wet car park, October 2026: the puddle doubles the car and its lights. Low, at the edge of the water. f/1.8, 1/80 s, ISO 1600.



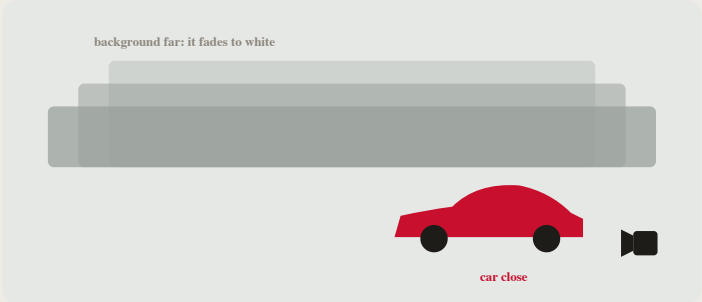
Umbrellas up, January 2025. f/1.8, 1/4000 s, ISO 5000.

# Fog, mist and frost

The photo on the cover of my book was made in fog, at ten past eight on a March morning. The fog hung over the frost until about twenty past nine.

- **Car close, background far** (diagram): distant things fade to white, so the scene simplifies itself.
- **+1 EV**, up to **+2 EV** when the mist is backlit: your meter sees fog as grey.
- **Focus on an edge**: a badge or a headlight ring. Autofocus hunts in low contrast.
- **People as shapes**: in fog they read instantly.
- **When it happens**: radiation fog forms on clear, nearly still nights, mostly in autumn and winter, and usually burns off in the morning. Be early.

> **Cold**
>
> Batteries drain fast: keep a spare warm in an inside pocket. Before you go indoors, seal the camera in a zip-lock bag and give it 30 minutes, or it steams up inside and out.






Frost, Fog and an Open Racer, Southside, March 2025: the book's cover. f/1.8, 1/8000 s, ISO 1600.

# Dusk and night

After sunset the open sky becomes one huge soft light, and headlights, light bars and street lamps start to glow. It's when many professional car photos are made.

| Situation | Settings | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Handheld, lights on | A mode, f/2 to f/5, ISO up to 6400 | Brace on something, keep 1/60 s or faster |
| Sky still blue | Expose for the sky and the lights | Let the ground go dark |
| Light trails | Tripod, 10 to 30 s, ISO 100, f/8 | Self-timer or remote; stabiliser off on a tripod |
| Lights on | Ask the owner | Daytime running lights and light bars read well even in dusk |

**Watch**

Blown headlights, very high ISO, and busy backgrounds full of other people's lights.



Lights On, The Fairmile, April 2026, 20:03: the last frame of the evening. f/5, 1/125 s, ISO 1250.

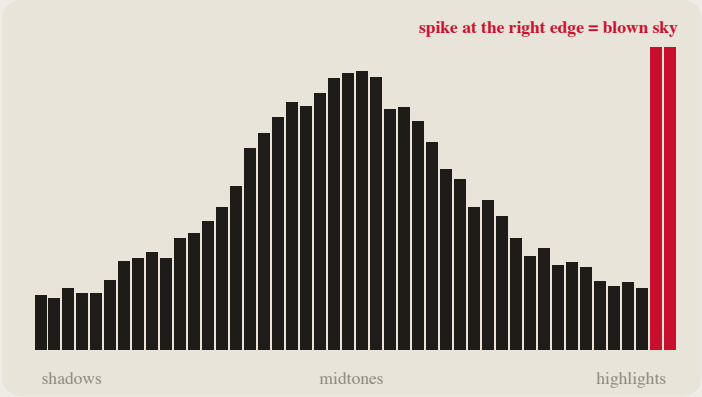
# Weather at a glance

| Weather | Expose | Stand | Shoot | Avoid |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Overcast | +0.3 to +0.7 EV on the car | Slightly high or low, sky thin | Whole cars, colour, faces | White sky across the frame |
| Hard sun | Protect highlights | 90° to the sun with a polariser | Shade, details, shadows | Hot spots, squinting faces |
| Low sun | For the bright side | Sun to the side, or behind the car | Shape, glow, long shadows | Flare without a plan |
| Rain | Raise ISO, keep 1/125 s | Low, for reflections | Puddles, beading, umbrellas | Water on the lens |
| Fog | +1 to +2 EV | Close to the car | Shapes, people, lights | Arriving late |
| Frost | +0.3 to +0.7 EV | Low, frost in the foreground | Grass, windscreens, breath | A cold camera indoors |
| Dusk | For the sky and lights | Braced, or on a tripod | Lights on, the open sky | Blown headlights |

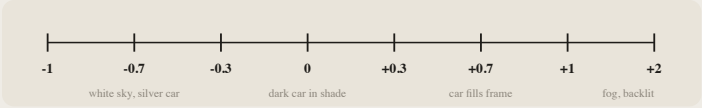
**The one rule**

There's no bad weather for photographs. Each kind just asks for different things. Check the forecast the night before and decide which page you're shooting from.

# Exposure: trust the histogram




A car-filled overcast frame should sit mostly in the middle. A tall spike jammed against the right wall is a white sky clipping: accept it (and frame tighter) or dial down.



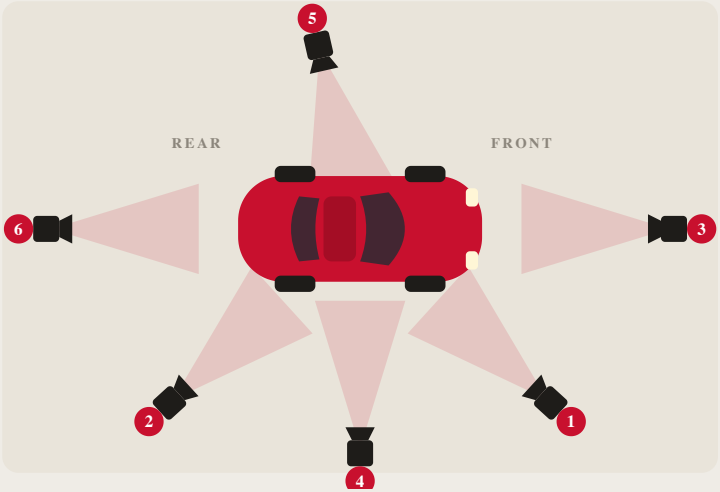

## Check routine (5 seconds)

- Turn on **highlights (blinkies)** and the **RGB histogram** in playback.
- Blinking car paint = too bright: dial down 0.3 EV. Blinking sky only = fine, unless the sky is part of the story.
- **Red channel**: red paint clips in red before the luminance histogram shows it. Check the RGB view on red cars and pull back 0.3 to 0.7 EV if the red hits the wall.
- Your look comes later: shoot RAW, keep the file flexible.
- Shooting low with tarmac filling the frame makes the meter darken: expect +0.3 EV.

### Exposure compensation quick table

Car fills frame: +0.3 to +0.7 · silver or white car: 0 to -0.3 (lots of white sky: -0.3 to -0.7) · dark car near a dark background: +0.7 to +1.0 · fog: +1 to +2

# The core angles formula

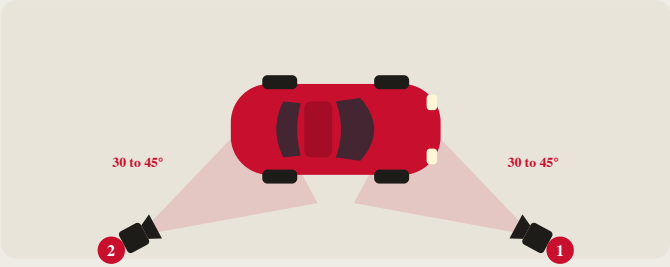



Camera icons point at the car; the car faces right. 5 = high angle (arms up, tilt screen, or a safe step).

| # | Angle | Zoom | 35 mm prime | Height |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Front three-quarter: the classic hero, 30 to 45° off the nose | 35 to 85 mm | Two car lengths back | Headlight or a little lower |
| 2 | Rear three-quarter: haunches, light bar, wing, exhausts | 50 to 85 mm | Two car lengths back | Tail-light |
| 3 | Low front / head-on: symmetrical, centred | 50 to 85 mm | Kneel, step back | Knee to bumper |
| 4 | Side profile: the roofline, wheelbase, stance | 70 to 135 mm | Far back, crop later | Door handle, square on |
| 5 | High: roof shape, plan view, clean background | 24 to 50 mm | Arms up | Above the roof |
| 6 | Straight rear: symmetry, full-width lights | 50 to 85 mm | Step back | Light-bar |



Cars on the Green, October 2026: a front three-quarter as the car rolls in, the wheel face towards the camera. f/2, 1/800 s, ISO 500.




## Front three-quarter recipe

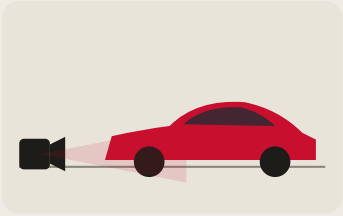
- Stand about **30 to 45° off the front corner**, so you see the face and the full flank.
- **Back off.** Close with a wide lens bloats the nose and shrinks the rear. With a zoom, 50 to 85 mm; with a 35 mm, two car lengths away.
- Height: **headlight level or a touch lower** for presence; eye level looks like a snapshot.
- **Front wheels turned so the wheel face points at the camera** (ask the owner; page 16).
- Fill about 70 to 80% of the frame; leave space in front of the nose.
- Watch the background behind the roofline: no poles growing from the car, no cones, no bins.

## Rear three-quarter recipe

- Mirror of the front: 30 to 45° off a rear corner, at **tail-light height**.
- On a 911, the money angle: the wide haunches, the engine lid and the light bar.
- A crouch emphasises a wing; standing tall shows the roofline curving into the tail.

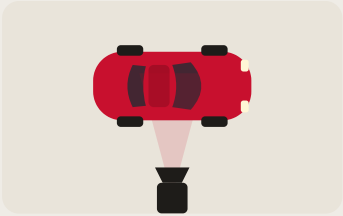
# Low front, profile, high angle, head-on

## Low front



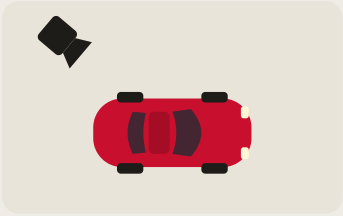
Get the lens down to bumper height. The sky shrinks, tarmac becomes a clean grey backdrop, and the car looks wide and planted. Step back rather than going wider.

## Side profile



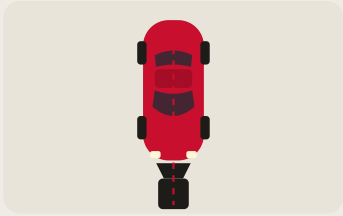
Square on to the middle of the car, lens at about door-handle height, so the wheels look round and the roofline is true. From as far back as you can get.

## High angle



Arms up with a tilting screen, or from a safe step. Shows the roof shape and cleans out clutter by using the tarmac as the background.

## Head-on



Dead centre on the badge, level camera, centred crop. Check both headlights sit at the same height in the frame. A 16:9 or square crop suits it.

### The weather twist

Low front and high angle are your two best weapons against a white sky: low puts tarmac behind the car, high puts tarmac below it. Save straight-on, eye-level frames with lots of sky for days when the cloud has texture.

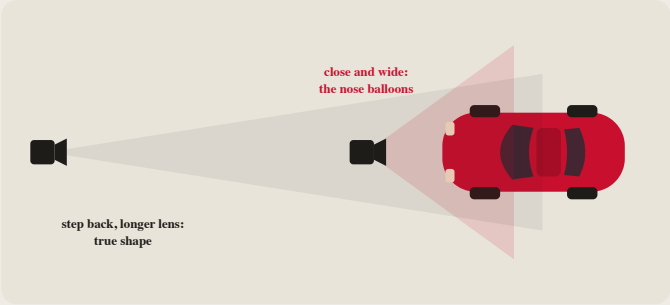
## Wheels and steering

- **Turn the front wheels 15 to 20° so the wheel face points at the camera** for a front three-quarter: you see the spokes, the caliper and the tyre wall, not the tread.
- **Steering wheel**: for interiors, centre it so the spokes are symmetrical and the badge is level.
- **Wheel alignment**: on five-spoke designs, roll the car slightly so a spoke points straight up, or the crest in the centre cap sits upright.
- Only ever ask: **the owner moves the car, never you.**




## Distance beats focal length

Perspective comes from where you stand. Close up with a wide lens, the nearest part of the car (the nose) balloons and the rear shrinks. Step back for honest proportions; step further back still to make the background bigger behind the car.




### Rule of thumb

For heroes, if you're closer than about two car lengths, you're probably too wide. Move your feet, not the zoom ring. With a 35 mm prime this is the whole game.

At a meet you take the car where it's parked. When an owner offers to move it for you, decide in this order: **light, angle, background**.

## Light

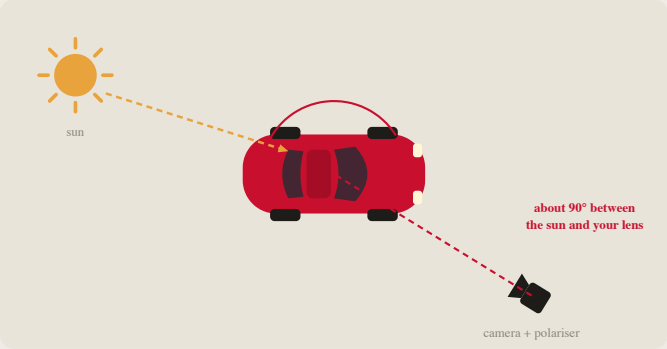
- Side light shows shape: aim for part of the car lit, part in shadow.
- Polariser at about 90° to the sun (page 6).
- Near midday, a car parked roughly in line with the sun picks out the character lines; it can take ten minutes of small moves to get right.

## Angle

- Front three-quarter to the camera, wheels turned 15 to 20° towards you.
- Camera at about wheel-hub height for natural proportions; lower for drama.

## Background

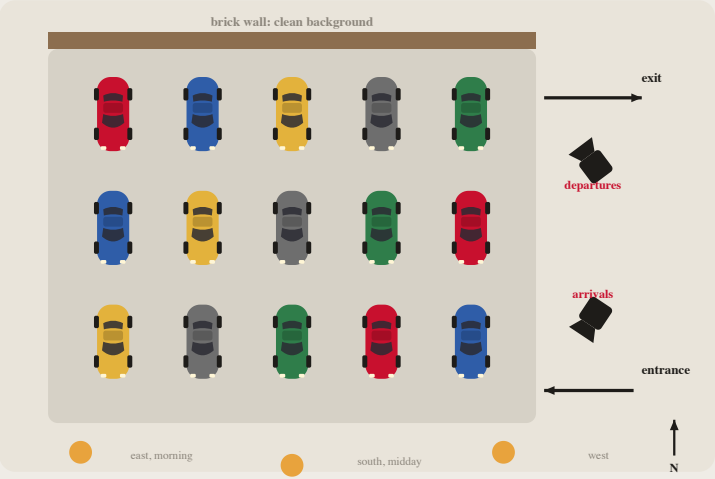
- Further from the background is better: the car separates and the background softens.
- Dark car on a bright background; light car against shade.
- Wear dark clothes: in glossy paint you're part of the picture. Clean the car; fingerprints show.






March 2026: a classic Mustang side on, a plain brick wall behind it, room to step back. f/2.8, 1/1600 s, ISO 400.

> **Safety**
>
> Nobody stands in the line of a moving car. On private land, ask the landowner or organiser before you start.




A meet from above: where cars come in and go out, the clean wall, and the sun moving from east to west across the south.

## Walk it first (10 minutes)

- **Light**: where is the sun, or the bright patch of sky? Which rows face it?
- **Backgrounds**: a hedge, a brick wall, an old building, open sky. Note the bins, cones, signs and portable toilets.
- **Entrance and exit**: that's where you'll shoot arrivals and pan departures. Stand where cars slow to turn, well back.
- **People**: the coffee van, the organiser, the rarest car. Story shots happen there.
- **The landmark**: the building, tower or sign that says where you are. Get one frame with it.

> **Read the venue's rules**
>
> Many meets are on private land on the owner's terms. Blackbushe Airport, for one, has a 15 mph limit and asks groups that rev or spin their wheels to leave.

# Finding a location for a shoot

For a planned shoot, most of the scouting happens at home. Here's how to start.

| Tool | Use it for |
|---|---|
| Google Maps, Earth, Street View | Surfaces, kerbs, backgrounds, which way buildings face, where you can park |
| PhotoPills / The Photographer's Ephemeris | The sun's direction and height at any spot, any time; PhotoPills can find the date and time the sun sits exactly where you want |
| Met Office | Hourly forecast, cloud and rain maps, warnings, 1 hour to 7 days |
| Clear Outside | Low, medium and high cloud by hour, dew point and frost: fog odds |

**Permission**

Public roads are public; car parks, airfields, estates and pubs belong to someone. National Trust places and big events have their own photography terms, especially for anything commercial.



The Fairmile, Cobham, April 2026: the pub behind the cars says where we are. f/5, 1/1250 s, ISO 640.

## What makes a good spot

- [ ] A clean, even surface: no painted bay lines through the car.
- [ ] A background with depth, in a tone that contrasts with the car.
- [ ] Room to step back for a profile.
- [ ] Quiet at the time you'll be there; the sun where you want it.



The crest, centred on pale blue paint. Blackbushe, October 2026.




Seats and tartan: the interior says how the car is used. April 2026.




Dials square to the camera, green paint behind. June 2025.



Four air trumpets in a blue engine bay. March 2025.

| Detail | How |
|---|---|
| Badges and crests | Fill the frame, shoot slightly off axis so the badge has depth, f/2.8 to f/4, focus on the lettering. Polariser to kill the sky reflection on chrome. |
| Wheels and calipers | Lens at hub height, square to the wheel or at a slight angle; caliper visible through the spokes. |
| Lights | Headlights and the rear light bar; ask if the owner can switch them on. Under cloud, LEDs read beautifully. |
| Interior | Ask first. Steering centred, from the door opening or through the window; raise ISO inside. A polariser lets you shoot through glass. |
| Wear and use | Stone chips, a creased seat, stickers from old events: they tell you the car is driven. |

# Signature shots: a worked example

Every marque has a handful of things only it does. Find them and you photograph *the* car, not a car. Here's how it works for Porsche, which I've photographed at several club meets.

## Shoot the silhouette

- **True profile** from far back, lens at mid-door height, so the curve isn't bent by perspective.
- **Roofline from the rear three-quarter, slightly high**: the 911's roof runs down into the engine lid.
- **Overcast bonus**: a soft highlight runs along the roof. Rotate the polariser until it sits as a clean line, not a smear.
- Against a dark building the silhouette pops; against white sky it disappears. Choose your background.

> **For any marque**
>
> Ask what an owner would recognise from one detail: a famous grille, a light signature, a badge, a roofline, the thing that has changed least in fifty years.




The rear of a 911 Turbo S: the wing, the script and the light bar. A wooden rail hides the plate. Blackbushe, October 2026. f/10, 1/60 s, ISO 200.

Not affiliated with or endorsed by Porsche or any other car maker. Marques are named only to describe their cars.

# Signature shots: lights, crests, wings, rows

| Signature | Formula |
|---|---|
| Rear light bar | Straight rear, centred, at light-bar height. Ask for the lights on: the full-width strip glows even in daylight under cloud. Symmetrical crop. Mind the plate below. |
| Crests | Bonnet crest, wheel-centre crests, the steering wheel boss. f/2.8 to f/4, fill the frame, slight angle. Wet or dewy cars are a bonus. |
| Wings | Rear three-quarter from a crouch so the wing breaks the skyline or sits against a building. Or a tight crop of the endplate and the script. |
| Centre-lock wheels | Square to the wheel at hub height, crest level, the big centre nut sharp. A wide aperture lifts it from the arch. |
| Generations lineup | If cars park in a row: stand at one end with a long lens and compress the line, old to new. Or ask owners for a few minutes to line up nose to tail for a profile series. |

**Plates**

Straight rears and lineups show plates. Frame so they're hidden behind another car, angle so they're unreadable, or blur them before posting.



long lens down the row

| Shot | Mode and exposure | ISO | Focus and drive |
|---|---|---|---|
| Statics (whole car) | A mode, f/4 to f/8 (f/5.6 is a safe default). Polariser on. | 100 to 400 if 1/focal length holds; up to 800 fine | Single point on the nearest headlight or badge |
| Busy street | S mode, 1/800 to 1/1600 s | Auto ISO | People and cars won't blur |
| Separation | A mode, f/1.8 to f/2.8 | Lowest the light allows | Focus carefully; depth is thin |
| Details | A mode, f/2.8 to f/4 | 100 to 400 | Pinpoint exactly on the script or caliper |
| People and owners | A mode, f/2 to f/2.8; keep 1/250 s or faster | Auto ISO, max 3200 | Eye or face detection, continuous |
| Panning | S mode, 1/60 s to start, 1/30 s for more blur | 100 to 200, or ND | Continuous AF, burst |
| Wide of the venue | A mode, f/8, horizon level | 100 to 400 | Single point a third into the scene |

| Light | What to do |
|---|---|
| Overcast | +0.3 to +0.7 EV on cars, minus when sky dominates; WB Cloudy or about 6000K |
| Sun breaks through | Lower ISO, watch hot spots on bonnets, use the polariser, -0.3 EV to protect highlights |
| Open shade | Soft light for portraits; WB Shade or about 6500K, +0.3 EV |

- **My history**: shutter priority and manual at first, aperture priority through 2025, shutter priority at 1/800 to 1/1600 s for busy streets in early 2026, then aperture priority around f/4.5 for the club meets.
- **Silent shutter** is unobtrusive for people, but use the mechanical shutter for panning to avoid rolling-shutter lean.
- Save a custom mode for statics and one for panning, so you're one turn of the dial away.

## Handheld

- **Stance**: feet shoulder-width, one foot slightly forward, knees soft.
- **Elbows tucked** into your ribs; left hand cradles the lens from below.
- **Eye to the viewfinder** gives a third point of contact.
- **Breathe** in, let half out, pause, squeeze.
- **Brace** on a wall, a post or a fence, never on someone's car.
- **Burst for sharpness**: two or three frames; the middle one is usually sharpest.
- **Check at 100%** on the back screen for the first few frames.

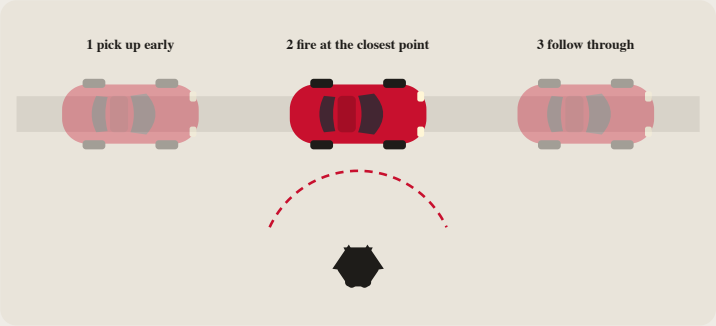
| Focal length | 1/focal (no IS) | With stabilisation* |
|---|---|---|
| 24 mm | 1/30 s | about 1/8 s |
| 35 mm | 1/40 s | about 1/10 s |
| 50 mm | 1/50 s | about 1/15 s |
| 85 mm | 1/90 s | about 1/30 s |

*Conservative: stabilisers are rated for 5 stops or so, but moving people still need 1/250 s.

## On a phone

| Do | Why |
|---|---|
| Main camera (1x), not the ultra wide | The ultra wide bends cars at the edges. Newer iPhones have 28 and 35 mm settings on the main camera; 2x is good for details. |
| Press and hold to lock focus and exposure | Then slide down to save a bright sky or white paint. |
| ProRAW (iPhone 12 Pro and later Pro models) | Far more room in the edit; 48 MP files are about 75 MB each, so watch storage. |
| Burst: slide the shutter button left | Arrivals, departures and people. |
| Gridlines on | Level horizons and centred head-ons. |

# Panning cars arriving and leaving




Rotate from the hips, the car side-on to you; a textured background (hedges, buildings, cars) streaks best.

- **S mode 1/60 s** to start, 1/30 s for more wheel and background blur; warm up at 1/125 s. Slow cars suit about 1/40 s, fast ones up to 1/120 s.
- **Continuous AF**, dynamic or wide area; **continuous high** burst.
- **Mechanical shutter** to avoid rolling-shutter lean.
- Pick a spot at the entrance or exit where cars pass **side-on and slowly**.
- Turn from the hips, keep the car in the same place in the frame, **keep panning after the shutter**.
- Expect 1 or 2 keepers per burst at slow speeds; that's normal.
- **Too bright for 1/30 s?** Lowest ISO, f/11 to f/16, polariser on. Overcast helps.

### Safety

Stand well back from the lane, never step into it, and follow the marshals. Rolling shots from another car are not for public roads: the driver can't hold a phone, everyone must wear a belt, and driving to match a photographer can count as driving without due care. Keep them for private land and track days.



Arriving at Cars on the Green, October 2026, the owner at the wheel. Frozen at 1/200 s, not panned. f/2, ISO 320.

## Cleaning the frame

- **Patience**: compose, wait for the gap, burst. People drift in waves.
- **Background first**: walk around the car before shooting; choose the side with tarmac, a wall or a clean row behind.
- **Height or depth**: go high to use tarmac as background, or low and close to blur the crowd.
- **Cones, bins, signs**: move your feet to hide them behind the car. Never move them yourself without asking.
- **Crowd as story**: when you can't beat them, shoot them, from behind or as soft shapes.
- **Children**: keep their faces out of anything you publish unless a parent is happy with it.

## Etiquette

- **Never touch a car** without asking: no leaning, no bags on bonnets; watch your strap, zips and lens hood near paint.
- **Approach owners openly**: compliment the car, say what you're photographing, and ask.
- **Ask** before opening doors, turning wheels, switching lights or shooting interiors.
- **Don't walk through other people's shots**; wait your turn at the hero car.
- **Offer to send a frame**: swap contacts, not names in captions.
- **Plates**: if an owner is uneasy, show them you'll blur it.
- Respect "no photos" and walk on with a smile.

> **Ready line**
>
> "Lovely car. I'm photographing the meet: cars and the people who love them. Would you mind if I took a few frames, maybe one of you with it?"

# Story shots: the people who love them

If you're going to your first meet tomorrow, the one thing I'd tell you is: **photograph the people.** At a meet the story is in the relationships: an owner polishing a wheel, friends comparing engine bays, a group gathering round one car.

| Story shot | Formula |
|---|---|
| Owner with car | Owner leaning near (not on) the car, the car in the background at f/2 to f/2.8 with eye AF, or wider at f/4 to show both. Open shade is flattering. |
| Conversations | Step back and let people forget you. Shoot without breaking the conversation: I was part of the one on the right and photographed it without interrupting it. |
| Hands and details of wear | Hands on a wheel, on a bonnet strap, pointing at an engine. 35 mm, f/2.8, close. |
| The crowd | A car that draws a crowd: stay with it. People gather, point, laugh and lean in. That's when the candid frames come. |
| The goodbye | As people leave they relax. "Smile for me" through an open window got me the last frame of my book. |



In the Middle of It, Blackbushe, October 2026: I was in the conversation and didn't interrupt it. f/1.8, 1/4000 s, ISO 160.



Two owners talk beside a classic Porsche, May 2025. f/1.8, 1/8000 s, ISO 400.

## Base

- **Profile**: a camera-matching profile as a starting point.
- **White balance**: start from Cloudy, then pick the neutral grey tarmac with the dropper and warm it slightly.
- **Exposure for bright midtones**: set it on the car or the faces, not the sky.
- Highlights down to rescue an overcast sky; a graduated mask on the sky if it's still blown.

## Your look

- **Lift shadows** moderately, then raise the black point on the tone curve for soft, lifted blacks.
- Keep contrast gentle; texture or clarity on the car only, not on faces.

## True reds

- Check the red channel histogram: if reds clip, lower exposure or red saturation and luminance slightly so texture returns to the paint.
- Nudge red hue a point or two to remove an orange or magenta cast; compare against the car itself.
- Avoid global saturation; use vibrance sparingly.
- Protect skin tones when adjusting reds.

## Before posting

- [ ] Blur or remove readable plates.
- [ ] Re-check crops: **no cut heads**, no limbs cut at joints.
- [ ] No names in captions unless people say yes.
- [ ] For Instagram, export at 1080 × 1350 (4:5).

> **The faster way**
>
> The last page has the one-click version of this edit.

# Printable checklist and shot list

TICK AS YOU GO

## Gear

- [ ] Camera, sensor checked
- [ ] 2 to 3 charged batteries, one warm
- [ ] Cards formatted, a spare
- [ ] Polariser (and ND if you pan in sun)
- [ ] Lens hood, microfibre cloth
- [ ] Rain cover or shower cap
- [ ] Zip-lock bag for going indoors
- [ ] Gloves with fold-back fingertips
- [ ] Phone charged, small cash for the coffee van
- [ ] Card or contact to offer owners

## Before the first frame

- [ ] RAW on, both card slots set
- [ ] White balance Cloudy or about 6000K
- [ ] A mode f/5.6, Auto ISO max 3200
- [ ] Highlights and RGB histogram on
- [ ] Eye detection on, AF-C ready
- [ ] Clock correct (for the metadata)
- [ ] Custom modes: statics and panning
- [ ] Walk the venue first

## Shot list

- [ ] Front three-quarter hero
- [ ] Rear three-quarter hero
- [ ] Low front
- [ ] Side profile
- [ ] High angle
- [ ] Badge or crest
- [ ] Wheel and caliper
- [ ] Lights on
- [ ] Interior (with permission)
- [ ] A lineup down a row
- [ ] The venue wide
- [ ] An arrival or departure
- [ ] Owner with their car
- [ ] A conversation
- [ ] Hands or wear
- [ ] The crowd

# Your meet

MEET AND VENUE

DATE

MEET STARTS

I ARRIVE (30 TO 45 MIN EARLY)

SUNRISE

SUNSET

FORECAST: CLOUD, RAIN, WIND (MET OFFICE)

FOG OR FROST CHANCE (CLEAR OUTSIDE)

LIGHT I EXPECT (CIRCLE)

Overcast | Hard sun | Low sun | Rain | Fog or frost | Dusk

PAGES TO REREAD FOR THAT LIGHT

VENUE RULES: ACCESS, SPEED, PHOTOGRAPHY, DRONES

WHERE THE SUN WILL BE WHEN I ARRIVE

Sketch the venue: entrance, rows, the sun, the cleanest backgrounds

# Your plan for the day

WRITE YOUR OWN TIMES

Start from my plan on page 3 and make it yours. Write the clock times, the cars you want and how you'll know a block is done.

| Time | Block | Shoot this | Done when | ✓ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Warm up | | | |
| | Heroes | | | |
| | Signatures | | | |
| | The venue | | | |
| | Story | | | |
| | Departures | | | |

IF TIME COLLAPSES, MY TOP FOUR FRAMES

SETTINGS I'LL START WITH (PAGE 23)

# Your shot list

TICK AS YOU GO

## Cars and angles

- [ ] Front three-quarter
- [ ] Rear three-quarter
- [ ] Low front
- [ ] Side profile
- [ ] High angle
- [ ] Head-on or straight rear
- [ ] A row down the lineup
- [ ] The venue wide
- [ ] An arrival or departure
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

## Details

- [ ] Badge or crest
- [ ] Wheel and caliper
- [ ] Lights on
- [ ] Interior (ask first)
- [ ] A wing, a vent, a line
- [ ] Wear: a stone chip, a worn seat
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

## Cars I must find

_____

_____

_____

## People and story

- [ ] An owner with their car (ask)
- [ ] A conversation
- [ ] Hands on a wheel or a cloth
- [ ] The crowd at its busiest
- [ ] Someone arriving or leaving
- [ ] One you nearly missed
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____
- [ ] _____

### Ten hero frames

Six of cars and four of people. Star them in camera as you go.

# Notes

WHAT WORKED

WHAT I'D CHANGE NEXT TIME

SETTINGS THAT WORKED (AND IN WHAT LIGHT)

OWNERS WHO ASKED FOR PHOTOS (FOR YOU ONLY, NEVER IN CAPTIONS)

# Sources

CHECKED OCTOBER 2026

The formulas come from my own meets and from established car photographers; the facts are checked against these sources.

**Lens and camera**: Nikon, NIKKOR Z 35mm f/1.8 S and Z6 II specifications (imaging.nikon.com).

**Polariser**: Autopix, Ten reasons to use a polarisation filter in car photography (autopix.no). Revant Optics on rainbow stress patterns in car glass.

**Light and positioning**: The Drive, How to take the best shot in the worst possible light. Adobe UK, Car photography. Joe Baraban on wet-downs.

**Perspective**: Digital Camera World and PetaPixel on lens "compression" being a matter of distance.

**Panning**: Fstoppers, Five tips to improve your panning. PhotographyTalk on motorsport panning.

**Fog**: Royal Meteorological Society (MetLink) on radiation fog; Digital Camera World on exposing for fog.

**Sun and twilight**: The Photographer's Ephemeris help pages; PhotoPills user guide.

**Phones**: Apple Support, About Apple ProRAW.

**Plates and data protection**: Information Commissioner's Office, exemptions guide and guidance on photos and public accounts; Carwow FOI to DVLA on plate cloning (April 2024).

**Places**: Blackbushe Airport car-meet rules (blackbushe.com/car-meets); The Royal Parks filming and photography policy (March 2026).

**Adverts**: ASA / CAP Code rule 6.1 and "Privacy: Permission".

**Drones**: Civil Aviation Authority, The Drone Code (March 2026).

**Roads**: The Highway Code, rules 98, 99 and 149; Road Traffic Act 1988, s.3ZA.

Photos: all my own, from my book *It started on a Sunday* and from meets in 2026; other owners' number plates hidden. Diagrams are simplified for clarity.

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David Silva

PHOTOGRAPHY

# Turn up early, stay late, be curious, and photograph the people too.

**The newsletter.** What I'm learning about photographing cars and building a photography business, as I go. Plain emails, no spam, unsubscribe any time. Join here: https://davidslv.photography/field-guide/

**The faster edit.** My KERBSIDE presets do the grey-morning fix from page 28 in one click: £8.99, https://davidslv.gumroad.com/l/kerbside-preset

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